KINGDOM LIFE MINISTRY

When Does the Day Begin?

Evening and Morning, From Creation to the Cross

A Midrash Study on Genesis 1:5, Leviticus 23:32, and How Yahshua Kept the Day

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with the Son's name rendered Yahshua and Messiah. Companion study to The Sabbath and The Seventh Day.

THE HEART OF IT

Most of us were raised on a clock that starts the day at midnight, a moment nobody can see. Rome gave us that clock. Scripture gives us a different one, and it is written into the sky: the day turns when the sun goes down.

This matters more than it looks. It decides when the Sabbath starts, when every appointed time begins, and how we read the last days of Yahshua's life. If we keep the right day at the wrong hours, we are still keeping it by someone else's clock.

So this study does what we always do. We go to the text, we look at the Hebrew and the Greek, we watch how Israel lived it and how **Yahshua** walked in it, and we look honestly at the verses people raise on the other side.

SECTION I

The Pattern at Creation

> *Elohim called the light "day", and the darkness he called "night". There was evening and there was morning, the first day.*
>
> **GENESIS 1:5**

Before there was any light, there was darkness. Genesis 1:2 opens with darkness on the face of the deep, and only in verse 3 does Elohim say, let there be light. Then Moses gives us the order of the very first day, and he repeats it six times: *evening, then morning.* Darkness first, then light. That is the shape of a day in YHWH's creation.

Erev: the sun going down

The word for evening is ערב, **erev** (Strong's H6153). It comes from a root that means to grow dark, the dusk that settles when the sun sets. It is not midnight and it is not late night. It is the turning point when daylight gives way.

Boqer: the break of day

The word for morning is בקר, **boqer** (H1242), from a root meaning to break open or break through. It is the light breaking through after the dark. Every day in Genesis 1 moves from erev to boqer, from dusk to dawn, and the two together make one day.

Yom echad: one day

The Hebrew does not actually say "the first day." It says יום אחד, **yom echad**, "one day" (H3117, H259). Evening plus morning equals one day. The Greek Septuagint reads it the same way: ἐσπέρα καὶ ἐγένετο πρωί, ἡμέρα

μία, *evening and morning, one day.*

Notice one thing so we read honestly. In the same verse, Elohim calls the light "day." So **yom** is used two ways in Scripture: the daylight part, and the whole evening and morning unit. Both are true, and they do not compete. The daylight is called day, and the full day is counted from evening.

SECTION II

The Torah Puts the Clock in Writing

Genesis shows us the pattern. The instructions write it down plainly, and the clearest place is the Day of Atonement.

> *"However on the tenth day of this seventh month is the day of atonement. It shall be a holy convocation to you. You shall afflict yourselves and you shall offer an offering made by fire to YHWH.*
>
> *It shall be a Sabbath of solemn rest for you, and you shall deny yourselves. In the ninth day of the month at evening, from evening to evening, you shall keep your Sabbath."*
>
> **LEVITICUS 23:27, 32**

Read that slowly. The Day of Atonement is the **tenth** day. Yet YHWH says to begin keeping it on the **ninth day at evening**, and to keep it "from evening to evening." The only way the tenth day can start on the evening of the ninth is if the day begins at evening. The Septuagint says it the same way: ἀπὸ ἑσπέρας ἕως ἑσπέρας, from evening until evening.

Unleavened Bread is counted the same way:

> *In the first month, on the fourteenth day of the month at evening, you shall eat unleavened bread, until the twenty first day of the month at evening.*
>
> **EXODUS 12:18**

And when a person was unclean "until the evening," the instruction tells us exactly when that ended:

> *the person that touches any such shall be unclean until the evening, and shall not eat of the holy things unless he bathes his body in water. When the sun is down, he shall be clean; and afterward he shall eat of the holy things, because it is his bread.*
>
> **LEVITICUS 22:6-7**

> *but it shall be, when evening comes, he shall bathe himself in water. When the sun is down, he shall come within the camp.*
>
> **DEUTERONOMY 23:11**

Uncleanness lasted until evening, and the new day of cleanness started **when the sun is down**. Not at midnight. Not at sunrise.

Ka-bo ha-shemesh: as the sun goes in

Over and over the Torah marks the boundary with the phrase בוא השמש, **bo ha-shemesh**, the going in of the sun (H935, H8121). Passover itself is tied to it:

> *but at the place which YHWH your Elohim shall choose to cause his name to dwell in, there you shall sacrifice the Passover at evening, at the going down of the sun, at the season that you came out of Egypt.*
>
> **DEUTERONOMY 16:6**

Ben ha-arbayim: between the evenings

In Exodus 12:6 the lamb is killed בין הערבים, **ben ha-arbayim**, literally "between the two evenings" (H996, H6153). Believers debate the exact window of that phrase, but either way it puts the Passover at the end of the fourteenth day, as the day closes toward sunset.

SECTION III

Israel Lived It

This was not a theory in a book. Israel kept time this way. When Nehemiah restored the Sabbath in Jerusalem, he shut the gates as the shadows fell:

> *It came to pass that when the gates of Jerusalem began to be dark before the Sabbath, I commanded that the doors should be shut, and commanded that they should not be opened until after the Sabbath. I set some of my servants over the gates, so that no burden should be brought in on the Sabbath day.*
>
> **NEHEMIAH 13:19**

The gates closed when Jerusalem "began to be dark before the Sabbath." The Sabbath was arriving with the dark, Friday evening.

When Esther called a fast, she said "three days, night or day" (Esther 4:16). Night comes first. And when Daniel heard how long the sanctuary would be trodden down, the angel did not say days. He said:

> *He said to me, "To two thousand and three hundred evenings and mornings. Then the sanctuary will be cleansed."*
>
> **DANIEL 8:14**

The Hebrew is ערב בקר, **erev boqer**, "evening morning." That is simply the Genesis 1 name for a day: one evening and one morning together.

Outside of Scripture, the first century historian Josephus, himself a priest, records that a priest stood on the roof at the corner of the temple and blew a trumpet to announce the beginning of every seventh day in the evening twilight, and again at evening when it ended (*Jewish War* 4.582). A stone inscription found at the base of the Temple Mount, reading "to the place of trumpeting," is widely believed to have marked that very spot.

SECTION IV

Yahshua Walked in It

Here is where it gets personal. Yahshua lived inside this evening to evening day, and the Gospels show it again and again. Watch what happens in Capernaum.

> *They went into Capernaum, and immediately on the Sabbath day he entered into the synagogue and taught.*
> **MARK 1:21**

> *At evening, when the sun had set, they brought to him all who were sick, and those who were possessed by demons.*
> **MARK 1:32**

> *When the sun was setting, all those who had any sick with various diseases brought them to him; and he laid his hands on every one of them, and healed them.*
> **LUKE 4:40**

It was the Sabbath. The whole town knew He was there, and the whole town waited. Why? Because they would not carry their sick on the Sabbath. The moment the sun set, the Sabbath was over, and the door filled up. Yahshua laid His hands on every one of them and healed them. He did not say, "Why did you wait until sunset? The Sabbath is not over yet." He received them at sundown, because the new day had begun.

The same clock runs through His burial:

> *When evening had now come, because it was the Preparation Day, that is, the day before the Sabbath,*
> **MARK 15:42**

> *It was the day of the Preparation, and the Sabbath was drawing near. The women, who had come with him out of Galilee, followed after, and saw the tomb, and how his body was laid. They returned and prepared spices and ointments. On the Sabbath they rested according to the commandment.*
> **LUKE 23:54-56**

> *Therefore the Jews, because it was the Preparation Day, so that the bodies wouldn't remain on the cross on the Sabbath (for that Sabbath was a special one), asked of Pilate that their legs might be broken, and that they might be taken away.*
> **JOHN 19:31**

They rushed to get His body down and into the tomb because evening was coming, and with the evening came the Sabbath. That Sabbath was a special one, the high Sabbath of Unleavened Bread. The women who loved Him stopped at sundown and rested "according to the commandment." His own disciples, the people closest to Him, kept the day from evening.

He corrected tradition, but never this

Yahshua was never shy about correcting Judah. He confronted their traditions to their faces:

> *He said to them, "Full well do you reject the commandment of Elohim, that you may keep your tradition.*
> **MARK 7:9**

He argued with them about *what* is lawful on the Sabbath, and taught that it is lawful to do good (Matthew 12:12). He healed on the Sabbath in front of them on purpose. Yet in all of those Sabbath confrontations, He never once questioned *when* the Sabbath began. Judah kept it from sunset to sunset, He kept it with them, and He never said a word against it.

READ THIS TWICE

An argument from silence is not proof on its own, and we should never claim more than the text says. But this is not empty silence. The One who corrected Judah on handwashing, oaths, corban, and Sabbath healing walked through every Sabbath of His life inside their evening to evening day, and the only record we have is of Him living in it.

Put that beside Genesis 1, Leviticus 23:32, and Nehemiah 13:19, and the witness is consistent from the first page to the cross.

SECTION V

The Greek Words

Hemera: day

ἡμέρα, **hemera** (G2250), is the normal Greek word for day. Like yom, it can mean the daylight hours or the whole day. Context decides.

Opsia and hespera: evening

ὀψία, **opsia** (G3798), is the late part of the day, the evening. Mark uses it in 1:32 (“at evening, when the sun had set”) and 15:42 (“when evening had now come”). ἑσπέρα, **hespera** (G2073), is the word the Septuagint uses for erev in Genesis 1 and Leviticus 23:32.

Nuchthemeron: a night and a day

When Paul says in 2 Corinthians 11:25, “I have been a night and a day in the deep,” he uses one word, νυχθήμερον, **nuchthemeron** (G3574). It is built from *nux*, night, and *hemera*, day, and it means a full twenty four hour day. Notice the order Paul, a trained Pharisee, reached for: **night first, then day.** It is the Greek twin of Daniel’s erev boqer.

Epiphosko: the Sabbath dawning at sunset

Luke 23:54 says the Sabbath “was drawing near.” The Greek is σάββατον ἐπέφωσκεν, **epephosken** (G2020), literally “was dawning” or “beginning to shine.” Luke uses it for **Friday evening**, as the sun went down and the Sabbath began. The Sabbath “dawned” at sunset. Keep this word in mind for the objections below, because it is the same word in Matthew 28:1.

Paraskeue and prosabbaton: the day before

παρασκευή, **paraskeue** (G3904), means preparation, the day you get ready. Mark explains it for his readers with προσάββατον, **prosabbaton** (G4315), “the day before the Sabbath” (Mark 15:42). Preparation ended, and Sabbath began, when evening came.

SECTION VI

Honest Objections

We do not hide the verses people raise. Here are the main ones, with what the text actually says.

1. “Genesis 1:5 says the light is called day.”

It does, and we covered it in Section I. Yom names the daylight and also the full evening and morning unit. The same verse that calls the light day then counts the whole day from evening.

2. “Matthew 28:1 says it began to dawn on the first day.”

> *Now after the Sabbath, as it began to dawn on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came to see the tomb.*
>
> MATTHEW 28:1

The verb is the same one Luke used for Friday at sunset, ἐπιφώσκω, epiphosko. Luke shows it was used for a day “dawning” at evening. So Matthew 28:1 cannot by itself prove the day starts at sunrise. Matthew’s phrase also opens with *opse sabbaton*, “late on the Sabbath” or “after the Sabbath.” Believers read the timing of the women’s visit differently, but the word does not overturn Leviticus 23:32.

3. “Passover night and the ‘next day’ in Numbers 33:3.”

Some point to Exodus 12:10 (nothing left until morning) and Numbers 33:3 (Israel left on the fifteenth, “the next day after the Passover”) and argue the day turned at morning. Others read the same verses with an evening start: the lamb was killed at the close of the fourteenth and eaten that night, which was already the fifteenth. Both sides use these verses. They are not clear enough to cancel the plain “from evening to evening” of Leviticus 23:32 and Exodus 12:18.

4. “People in Scripture say ‘tomorrow’ after a night.”

Genesis 19:34 and Judges 19:9 speak of “the next day” after a night, the way we still talk. That is everyday speech about getting up in the morning, the daylight sense of yom. Even Acts 4:3 holds the apostles “until the next day, for it was now evening,” meaning until the next daylight when the council could meet.

5. “Yahshua said there are twelve hours in the day.”

In John 11:9 He asks, “Aren’t there twelve hours of daylight?” He is talking about the daylight hours for walking and working, not where the full day starts.

THE HONEST BOTTOM LINE

Not every verse in Scripture uses the word day the same way, and everyday speech often counts by daylight. But every place where YHWH sets the boundaries of a commanded day, the Sabbath, Atonement, Unleavened Bread, cleansing, He sets the boundary at evening, when the sun goes down. That is the clock to keep.

SECTION VII

Walking It Out

The Sabbath starts Friday at sunset and ends Saturday at sunset. Not Saturday morning, and not at midnight. Plan your week so the work is done before the sun goes down Friday, and welcome the Sabbath as it arrives.

Every appointed time begins the evening before. Passover, Unleavened Bread, Yom Teruah, Atonement, Tabernacles, and the eighth day all begin at sundown on the evening that opens that day on the calendar.

Watch the sky, not the clock. Sunset moves through the year. YHWH put the lights in the heavens for signs and seasons, for days and years (Genesis 1:14). The sun going down is His bell.

See the picture He painted. YHWH starts every day in darkness and moves it toward light. That is the story of creation, and it is the story of every life He redeems. We begin in the dark, and He brings the morning.

> *But the path of the righteous is like the dawning light that shines more and more until the perfect day.*
> **PROVERBS 4:18**

> *Again, therefore, Yahshua spoke to them, saying, "I am the light of the world. He who follows me will not walk in the darkness, but will have the light of life."*
> **JOHN 8:12**

So when the sun goes down this Friday, remember: the day is not ending. A new one is beginning, and it begins with rest.

SECTION VIII

Word Study Reference

erev H6153 ערב Evening, dusk as the sun sets. Genesis 1:5; Leviticus 23:32; Exodus 12:18. Septuagint: ἑσπέρα.

boqer H1242 בקר Morning, the break of day. Genesis 1:5; Daniel 8:14. Septuagint: πρωί.

yom H3117 יום Day: the daylight hours, or the full evening and morning unit. Genesis 1:5, 14.

echad H259 אחד One. "Yom echad," one day, Genesis 1:5.

laylah H3915 לילה Night. Genesis 1:5; Esther 4:16.

bo ha-shemesh H935, H8121 בוא השמש The going in of the sun, sunset. Deuteronomy 16:6; Leviticus 22:7; Deuteronomy 23:11.

ben ha-arbayim H996, H6153 בין הערבים Between the evenings, the close of the day. Exodus 12:6.

erev boqer ערב בקר Evening morning, a full day. Daniel 8:14.

hemera G2250 ἡμέρα Day, daylight or a full day. John 11:9.

opsia G3798 ὀψία Evening, late in the day. Mark 1:32; 15:42.

hespera G2073 ἑσπέρα Evening. Luke 24:29; Acts 4:3; Septuagint Genesis 1:5 and Leviticus 23:32.

nuchthemeron G3574 νυχθήμερον A night and a day, a full twenty four hours, night first. 2 Corinthians 11:25.

epiphosko G2020 ἐπιφώσκω To dawn, to begin to shine. Used of the Sabbath beginning Friday evening, Luke 23:54; Matthew 28:1.

paraskeue G3904 παρασκευή Preparation, the day before a Sabbath. Mark 15:42; John 19:31.

prosabbaton G4315 προσάββατον The day before the Sabbath. Mark 15:42.

SECTION IX

Cross Reference Index

Creation pattern: Genesis 1:2-5, 8, 13, 19, 23, 31; Genesis 1:14

Evening to evening: Leviticus 23:27, 32; Exodus 12:18

Sunset boundary: Leviticus 11:24-25; Leviticus 22:6-7; Deuteronomy 16:6; Deuteronomy 23:11; Joshua 8:29; Joshua 10:27

Israel kept it: Nehemiah 13:19; Esther 4:16; Daniel 8:14

Yahshua and the day: Mark 1:21, 32-34; Luke 4:40; Mark 15:42; Luke 23:54-56; John 19:31

Tradition corrected: Mark 7:1-13; Matthew 15:1-9; Matthew 12:1-14

Night then day: 2 Corinthians 11:25

Verses raised on the other side: Matthew 28:1; Exodus 12:10; Numbers 33:3; Genesis 19:34; Judges 19:9; John 11:9; Acts 4:3

Darkness to light: Proverbs 4:18; John 8:12; 1 John 1:5; 2 Corinthians 4:6

NOTES

Personal Notes and Convictions

Walk in truth. Walk in Light. Shalom.

Kingdom Life Ministry

Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.